

THE FUTURE OF EDUCATION

"We want a marriage between technology and teachers"

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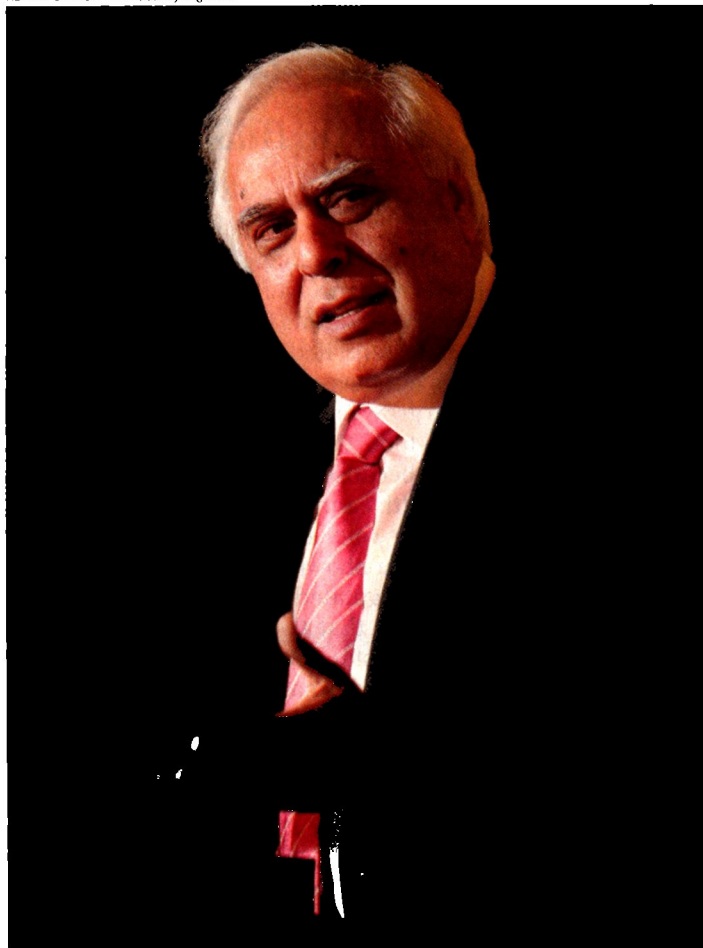
We are confronted with a collapsing past and an uncertain future. All the methodologies of the past have changed. And we are confronted with new issues. We need infinite possibilities to conquer the challenges of tomorrow. The question is how will it happen? And I submit that we will meet the challenges through intangible assets. The wealth of corporations and nations will depend on intangible assets. Knowledge is at the heart of making intangible assets. I would suggest that if a nation wants to be wealthy it must invest in knowledge, which means investing in our children. When I look upon education, I look up on it as determining India's future.

Now where is wealth really created? The foundation of that wealth is primary and secondary education. And unless we ensure there is a critical mass of children who move from school to college we will not have the kind of people who will create the wealth we are talking about. And so I think the most important piece of legislation that we have passed is the Right to Education Act. It is the first time that the state has committed itself to ensure access for all Indian children to quality schooling. The Act enjoins the state government to ensure that every neighbourhood has a school. Any community that does not have access to a school now has not just a statutory right under the Act, but a constitutional right to quality schooling.

Our education policy stands on three pillars: access, which is ensured by the Right to Education Act itself; inclusiveness, for which we have a provision in the Act which says private schools must take in 25 per cent of the students from neighbourhood belonging to the disadvantaged sections from Class I. So from April 1, 2010, 25 per cent of Class I students will be from the disadvantaged section. The next year there will be a fresh intake of 25 per cent of Class I students from the disadvantaged section. So, in 12 years 25 per cent of students will be from disadvantaged sections. And of course, quality, which is ensured by the qualification of the teachers.

To implement the Act is not easy. And this is consistent with the concept of decentralisation because I don't think the Central government can monitor neighbourhood schools in the hinterlands. So being consistent with the

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73rd and 74th Amendments to the Constitution where panchayats are responsible for schools, we have ensured that the managing committees of these schools shall comprise 75 per cent of the local community.

There will be problems. One is absenteeism. How do you ensure teachers actually go to school? Start using technology; there is no other way. But what we ultimately want is a marriage between technology and teachers. We have to use technology but it by itself cannot be an answer.